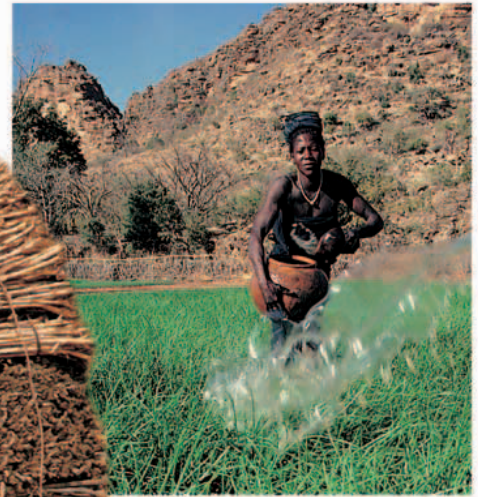




The Dogon have a profound knowledge of astronomy. They determine the time of one of their ceremonies by the position of the distant star, **Sirius**. Dogon priests have long maintained that Sirius had a companion star—

invisible to the naked eye—which Western astronomers finally managed to locate in 1995. Dogon stories about the creation and workings of the universe are some of the most complex known to anthropologists.

The toguna or "House of Words" is the spiritual center of Dogon life. It has a low roof so that no one can stand up and start fighting if there is a disagreement.



THE ONION CROP

The Dogon grow onions as a cash crop. These are pounded, shaped into balls, and dried in the sun. They will be taken by truck as far away as the Ivory Coast to be sold as ingredients for sauces. The pots used to water the crop are made out of clay by Dogon women.

The "chess-board" pattern symbolizes the relationship between the spirit world and the world of the living.

PROBLEMS WITH TOURISTS

Decorative gate posts were a feature of Dogon buildings but many were stolen by art collectors and tourists. These days few are made, and the Dogon have resorted to defacing the remainder so that no one will be tempted to steal them.

